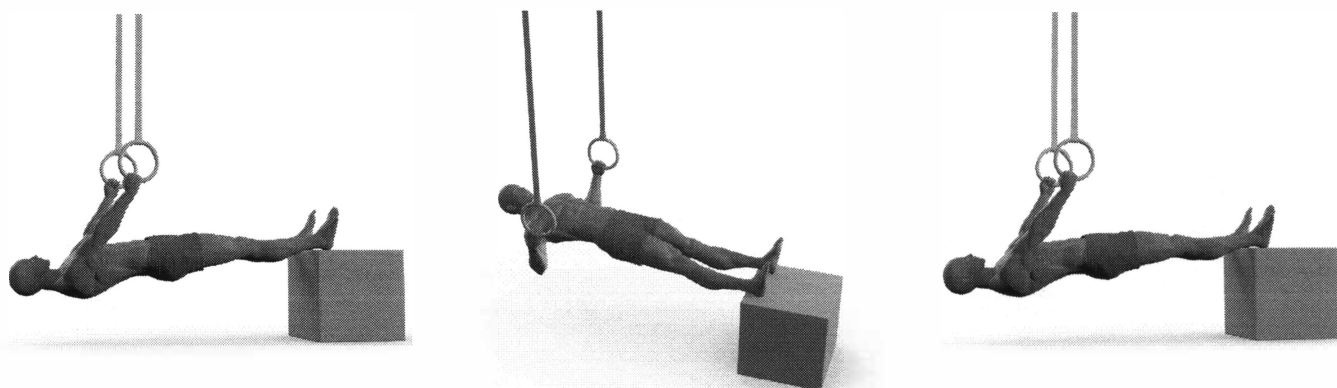


WIDE RING ROWS – LEVEL 3



Scapular Positioning: Begin at the bottom position with your shoulders relaxed in a protracted position. Initiate the movement by retracting and depressing your scapulas and end the movement with fully retracted scapulas and your arms wide.

Technique: *Wide rings rows* are performed by hanging from the rings and elevating your feet to shoulder height while your body is held straight or slightly hollow. From this position, allow your elbows to move wide to a sixty to ninety degree angle with your torso. Sixty degrees (shown in the images above) is the easiest, but you can work your way up to ninety degrees as you become more proficient with the skill. During the movement, allow your hands to drift away from your body and aim to pull your elbows in line with your body, preferably behind you to bring your torso to hand-height.

The most common fault during this skill is again to let your body sag from the straight-body position into a hollow or saggy C-shaped position. Focus on squeezing your glutes and core to keep your body straight and perform the movement with your arms alone.

If the posterior part of your shoulder is particularly weak, wide ring rows (if you are able to perform them) will pull your elbows out significantly. This will target your posterior deltoids better than the hands-in variation.

ARCHER RING ROWS – LEVEL 4



Scapular Positioning: Begin at the bottom position, with your shoulders relaxed in a protracted position. Initiate the movement by retracting and depressing your scapulas and end the movement with fully retracted scapulas. Even though your arms are performing different motions, your scapular positioning will be the same for both arms.

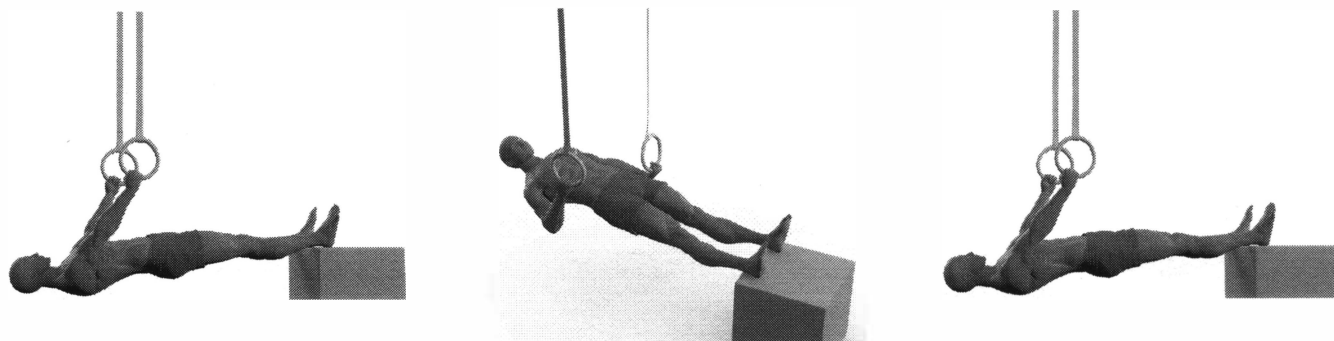
Technique: *Archer rings rows* are performed by hanging from the rings and elevating your feet to shoulder-height while holding your body straight. From this position, pick one arm to bend and one arm to hold straight. Your bent arm will be pulled either in or out with your elbow so it becomes level with your body. (Pulling it in closer to your body better relates to FL rows.) Your straight arm should be pulled out in a ninety-degree angle with your body, such as in a reverse fly exercise so your scapula retracts and your arm ends level with your body. From this point, lower in a controlled manner and repeat the movement with your other arm.

Once again, the common fault during this skill is to let your body sag from the straight-body position into a hollow or saggy C-shaped position. Focus on squeezing your glutes and core to keep your body straight and perform the movement with your arms alone.

Some people have a lot of difficulty progressing to the archer ring rows from wide ring rows. This is usually due to scapular weakness, as your straight arm only pulls with the posterior shoulder muscles and scapular muscles. Weaknesses there will manifest in an inability to pull high, if at all. To counteract this, some of the same concepts that applied to ring row eccentrics can help you bridge the gap:

- Perform wide ring rows to the top of the movement and then perform a straddle archer row eccentric to the bottom of the movement. This combines the two movements, so you are able to work the eccentric portion partially. If you choose this, your eccentrics should be at least five seconds.
- Instead of positioning your body parallel with the ground, stand more upright and have your feet on the ground. Raise the rings or bar and remove the block from your feet if needed.
- Perform ring row eccentrics in a position with a straddle or bent legs, or from the hips. This will take weight off your arms, which will make the movement easier.
- Put a band through the rings or bar and underneath your back.
- Have another person assist you through the movement.

ARCHER-ARM-IN RING ROWS – LEVEL 5

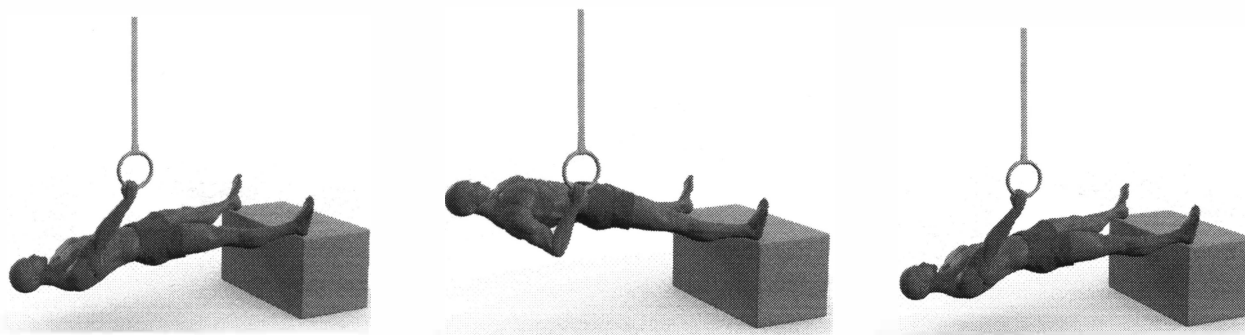


Scapular Positioning: Begin at the bottom position, with your shoulders relaxed in a protracted position. Initiate the movement by retracting and depressing your scapulas and end the movement with fully retracted scapulas. Even though your arms are performing different motions, your scapular positioning will be the same for both arms.

Technique: *Archer-arm-in ring rows* are performed by hanging from the rings and elevating your feet to shoulder-height while holding your body straight. From this position, pick one arm to bend and one arm to hold straight. Your bent arm will be pulled either in or out with your elbow so it becomes level with your body. (Pulling it in closer to your body better relates to *FL rows*.) Your straight arm should be pulled in line with your body, which will cause it to end at your side. From this point, lower in a controlled manner and repeat the movement with your other arm.

This movement helps you build more posterior shoulder strength in your straight arm so that you can more easily move to one-arm rows. Since you can assist less with your straight arm at that angle, it makes your bending arm pick up more of the work. This is a pretty solid bridge between archer ring rows and the straddle one-arm row progression. *This “in” position will also help strongly work your posterior shoulder, which will be beneficial to stave off any shoulder imbalances.*

STRADDLE ONE-ARM ROWS – LEVEL 6



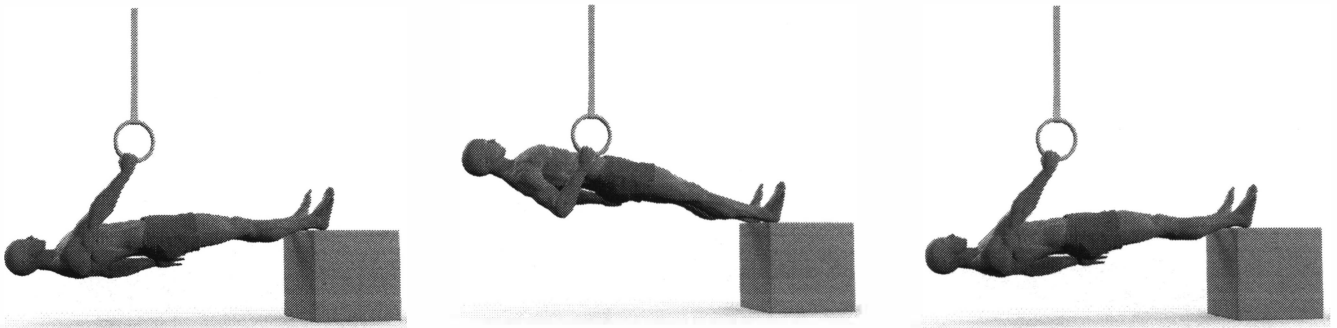
Scapular Positioning: Begin at the bottom position, with your shoulders relaxed in a protracted position. Initiate the movement by retracting and depressing your scapulas and end the movement with fully retracted scapulas.

Technique: *Straddle one-arm rows* are performed by gripping a ring with one arm and putting your feet on a block in the straddle position. Your feet should be at shoulder-height. Keep your body straight by maintaining a tight core and hips. With straight-body positioning and one arm on a ring, pull while keeping your elbow in so that your hand comes as close to your body as possible. You will probably not be strong enough to pull all the way to your body with one arm, but get as close as possible. To “finish” this movement it is also possible to go one step further and rotate your body in toward your pulling arm so that your opposite shoulder touches the ring or bar.

When performing single-arm or single-leg movements like *straddle one-arm rows* (which can be abbreviated *Str OA rows*), always begin with your weak arm during sets. You can either perform alternated repetitions (where you trade off repetitions to the opposite arm every one) or full sets first before switching. As long as you work your weak arm first to equalize your strength, both are good options. You should always limit the number of repetitions on your strong arm to what your weak arm can handle.

While performing the one-arm row portion of this movement, you may notice a torque or twisting feeling. This is a common issue, and should be fought. Typically, it will manifest as a lot of pressure in the arm that is doing the work, as well as the opposite foot. Your body may want to rotate, twist, or move out of alignment, but you must tense up your core and hip muscles to stop it.

ONE-ARM ROWS – LEVEL 7



Scapular Positioning: Begin at the bottom position, with your shoulders relaxed in a protracted position. Initiate the movement by retracting and depressing your scapulas and end the movement with fully retracted scapulas.

Technique: *One-arm rows* are performed by gripping a ring with one arm and putting your feet up on a block with your legs together. Your feet should be at shoulder-height. Keep your body straight by maintaining a tight core and hips. Pull while keeping your elbow in so that your hand comes as close to your body as possible. You will probably not be strong enough to pull all the way to your body with one arm, but get as close as possible. To “finish” this movement, go one step further and rotate your body toward your pulling arm so that your opposite shoulder touches the ring or bar.

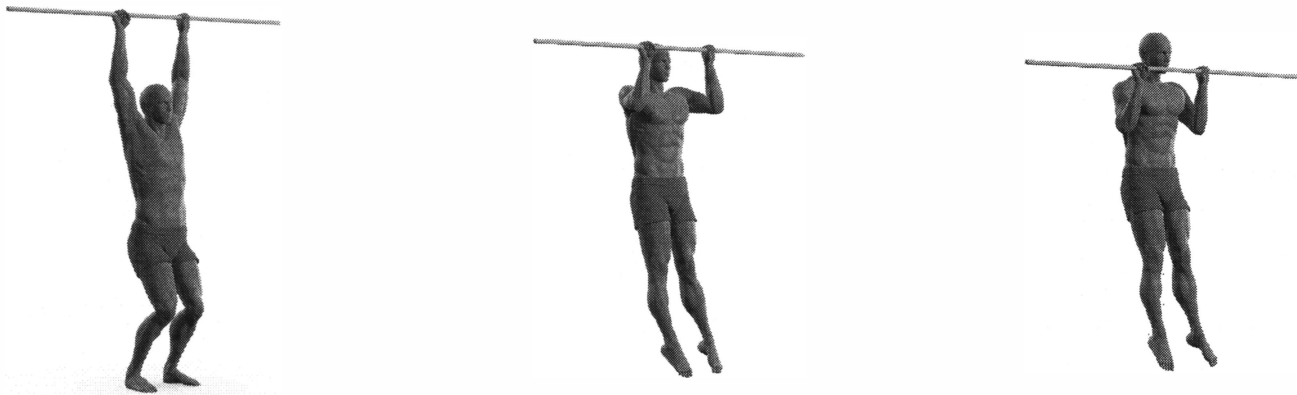
The torque or twisting feeling from the previous progression (*straddle one-arm rows*) will be much more prevalent when performing one-arm rows. Fight against it in the same manner as advised in the previous progression.

This is the final progression in this series. Once you reach this level of strength, move to the previous series of progressions (*front lever rows*) or add a weight vest to this series of progressions (*rowing*) to make them more challenging.

Pull-ups – Page 2, Column 5

This book does not address a wide array of bar pull-ups because pull-ups and chin-ups tend to work best for developing basic level strength. Once that strength is developed, you will typically move on to more difficult movements like weighted pull-ups or one-arm chin-ups. Front lever progressions and other pulling-based static and dynamic exercises tend to be more effective than pull-ups for overall progress.

JUMPING PULL-UPS – LEVEL 1



Scapular Positioning: Begin with your scapulas relaxed and elevated. Initiate the movement by depressing your scapulas as you rise to the top of the position and pull down with your arms and chin over the bar.

Technique: Begin with your arms straight, your shoulders open, and your knees slightly bent. (You can put a box or other object under your feet if you cannot lower a pull-up bar or rings enough to perform this movement.) Jump with as little force as possible so that your arms perform most of the work to pull your chin up and over the bar. If you can, work the movement so your clavicles or chest touch the bar instead. Keep your elbows narrow and in front of you.

Jumping pull-ups use your legs to adjust for insufficiency in pulling strength. Even though the force from the jump will make the pull-up easier during both the ascending and descending portions, you should use your arms to do as much of the work as possible and minimize contribution from your legs. Your aim is to increase pulling strength in your arms.

Try to get your clavicles to the bar for chin-ups. The reason why you do not want to focus on getting just your chin above the bar is because most people will crane their necks to do so. From a performance perspective, this is poor execution. Remember, you will eventually be working skills with a much greater range of motion. Practice this skill with the greatest range of motion possible.

Craning your neck can also inhibit force generation as it narrows the passages in your spine where your nerves come out, which can pinch some of the nerves that innervate the muscles required to do the pull-up. This pinching and craning/straining motion on your neck may also cause tension headaches and tight muscles.

BAR PULL-UP ECCENTRICS – LEVEL 2

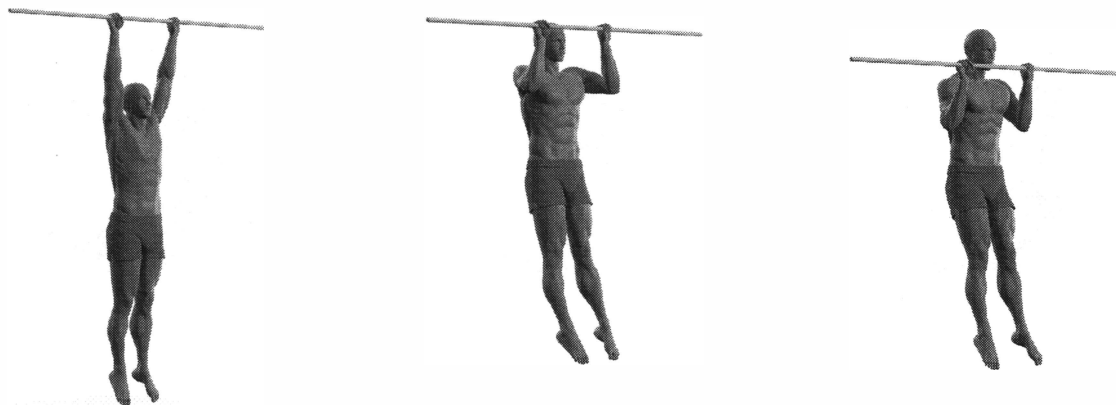
Scapular Positioning: Begin at the top of the bar with your scapulas depressed and slightly retracted. Slowly lower to the bottom, allowing your scapulas to progressively elevate so you finish in a relaxed position.

Technique: Begin at the top of the bar and slowly lower to a full hang position.

Eccentrics are one of the best ways to increase strength for movements that you cannot yet perform, when you have enough strength to control the descending portion. Aim to work up to holding the negative portion of the pull-up for six to eight seconds and perform two to three sets of two to three repetitions per set. Eventually, you may need three to five sets of seven to ten seconds pull-ups in order to perform full repetitions. Focus on activating your lats and biceps as much as possible.

Assistance can be used to gain strength at this level. This could come in the form of a Gravitron machine, pulley system, a spotter lifting your hips or legs, or placing a resistance band at your feet to reduce the load for the ascending portion of the movement. A combination of unassisted slow negatives and assisted positives are invariably effective for attaining pull-ups.

BAR PULL-UPS – LEVEL 3



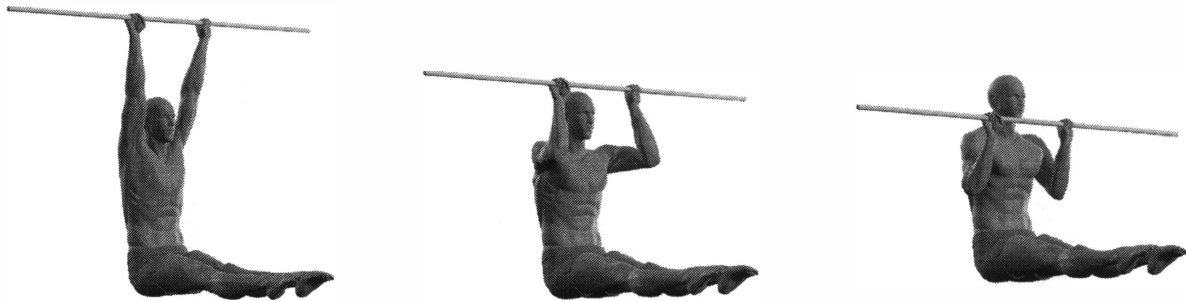
Scapular Positioning: Begin from a hang position, with your shoulders fully relaxed and scapulas elevated. Initiate the movement by depressing your scapulas. As you move through the position, they will naturally rotate and retract slightly until you reach the top position.

Technique: Begin from a hang position. Pull your chin over the bar by driving your elbows toward and past your sides. Aim to get your clavicles to the height of the bar without craning your neck. Then, lower back down to a hang position in a controlled manner. Your elbows should remain in line with your body, not flared out.

Bar pull-ups are the typical pull-ups you see performed in elementary school gym class. You do not want to have your elbows out wide while performing this movement, as this will limit your vertical pulling ability as your shoulder closes. Learning the position wrong will eventually make it difficult to move your chest past the bar in subsequent progressions. Keep your elbows in.

If you are having problems, you can work negatives, assisted pull-ups, or use a Gravitron machine if you have access to one at your local gym. Remember to tense your core and entire shoulder girdle before pulling, as doing so will help transmit the force needed to lift your body.

L-SIT PULL-UPS – LEVEL 4



Scapular Positioning: Begin from a hang position, with your shoulders fully relaxed and scapulas elevated. Initiate the movement by depressing your scapulas. As you move through the position they will naturally rotate and retract slightly until you reach the top position.

Technique: Hang from the bar in an L-sit position. Your hands will be pulled four to six inches in front of your body, past your chin to your clavicles. As you unlock your shoulders at the beginning of the movement, focus on pushing your hands forward (like the front lever position) and pulling your arm into your shoulder socket. Once your shoulders are stabilized, perform the pull-up portion of the skill with your hands in front of you. Do not allow your legs to drop lower than parallel with the ground in the L-sit position. Finish with your clavicles or chest against the bar and slowly lower back to the starting position.

The most difficult portions of *L-Sit pull-ups* are at the beginning (when you are unlocking your shoulder joint) and at the top (where your muscles are short and therefore disadvantaged—especially if you are aiming to get further over the bar). L-Sit pull-ups are more difficult than standard pull-ups due to an increase of torque at your shoulder. Since bringing your legs up in front of the body pushes your center of mass forward, your shoulders have to push forward to keep your center of mass under the bar. Therefore, when hanging in the L-position your hands should be slightly in front of your torso. Obviously, this does not have too much of an effect while you are just hanging; however, when you start to perform a pull-up it can be difficult.

As you fatigue, you may run into issues with your rotator cuff muscles. (This is also the case with *wide-grip pull-ups*.) Since your rotator cuff helps keep your humeral head from riding up into your acromion, your muscles lose their ability to exert force as you fatigue. Since L-Sit pull-ups increase torque at your shoulder (due to constantly pushing your hands forward), your rotator cuff muscles will fatigue much faster. This can lead to impingement.

Do not place this progression near the end of your routine, as this is when you will be most fatigued. It may also be a good idea to perform supplemental rotator cuff muscle work, such as LYTPs, side-lying external rotations, the middle portion of the Cuban press, or band external rotation.

PULLOVER – LEVEL 5



Scapular Positioning: Begin from the hang position, with your shoulders fully relaxed and scapulas elevated. Initiate the movement by depressing your scapulas. As you move through the position, they will naturally rotate and retract a bit until you reach the top of the position. As you bring your legs through the L-sit and over your head, keep your scapulas depressed and retract them strongly to keep your torso close to the bar as you rotate over the top.

Technique: The *pullover* is a basic gymnastics movement that involves manipulating your body upside down, around, and over the bar. This movement can be broken into three different parts for coaching.

1. The first part of the movement is a clavicle-to-bar pull-up. It is better if your chest is brought to the bar, so try to pull as high as possible.
2. The goal of the second phase of the movement is to invert your body and get your hips to the bar. Do this by leaning back and allowing your arms to straighten out. While your arms are straightening, your hips must be spun up to the bar. This is easier to perform in the tuck or pike positions, but should eventually be performed with straight-body positioning.

After your hips are brought to the bar, the third phase of the movement includes a partially inverted pull-up, as well as pushing your hips and legs further over the bar. From there, your body will begin to rotate, as more of your body mass is on the opposite side of the bar. Ultimately, your body will end up on top of the bar. Your arms should be straightened, which will cause you to end up in the support position when you are on top of the bar.

This skill may be difficult to figure out by yourself. It is much easier if you can get a spotter to spot your hip motions. You can also perform this skill in reverse, starting from over the top of the bar. This will help you develop strength and awareness for this skill.

This is an A-level skill in the Gymnastics Code of Points.

Ring Pull-ups + One-Arm Chin-ups – Page 2, Column 6**RINGS L-SIT PULL-UPS – LEVEL 4**

Scapular Positioning: Begin from the hang position, with your shoulders fully relaxed and scapulas elevated. Initiate the movement by depressing your scapulas. As you move through the position, they will naturally rotate and retract a bit until you reach the top of the position.

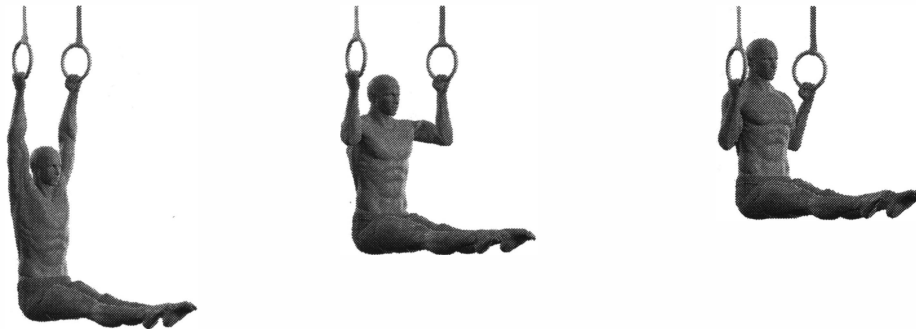
Technique: Hang from the bar in an L-sit position. Your hands will be pulled four to six inches in front of your body, all the way to clavicle-height and eventually chest-height as you grow stronger. The most difficult portions of this movement are at the beginning (when you are unlocking your shoulder joint) and at the top (where your muscles are short and therefore disadvantaged—especially if you are aiming to get further over the bar).

Rings L-sit pull-ups are no harder than the variation on the bar. If rings are not available, switching to the bar is perfectly acceptable. For the unlocking of your shoulders at the beginning of the movement, focus on pushing your hands forward (similar to the front lever position), and pulling your arm into your shoulder socket.

RINGS WIDE GRIP PULL-UPS – LEVEL 5



RINGS WIDE GRIP L-SIT PULL-UPS – LEVEL 6



Scapular Positioning: Begin from the hang position, with your shoulders fully relaxed and scapulas elevated. Initiate the movement by depressing your scapulas. As you move through the position, they will naturally rotate and retract a bit until you reach the top of the position.

Technique: Begin in a hang position on the rings with your hands neutral or facing forward (pronated grip). From there, pull your elbows out. Attempt to keep the forearms as vertical as possible during the movement.

The *rings wide grip L-sit pull-up* is the same movement, but in the L-sit position starting at the beginning of the movement and maintaining it throughout. As with the prior L-sit movements, it may be useful to push the rings slightly forward first and tense your shoulders to initiate the movement.

It is certainly possible to get the rings to clavicle or chest level, but most people will not get this high when first attempting these movements. This is a lats-dominated exercise with less emphasis on the biceps, so it will be useful for many different rings progressions.

Wide grip pull-ups and archer pull-ups may bother your shoulders and cause discomfort or pain as your rotator cuff muscles fatigue. Do not place this progression near the end of your routine when you will be most fatigued. It may also be a good idea to perform supplemental rotator cuff muscle work, such as LYTPs, side-lying external rotations, the middle portion of the Cuban press, or band external rotation.

Generally speaking, be careful with wide grip pull-ups when you are fatigued, as your shoulder will be vulnerable while in a fully externally rotated state with a distraction force like pull-ups. You should avoid this movement if you have shoulder subluxation or shoulder dislocation issues. Performing wide grip pull-ups with the rings, however, allows for movement of your shoulders into a position of lower resistance. This should help avoid soft tissue impingements or other such injuries.

RINGS ARCHER PULL-UPS – LEVEL 7



Scapular Positioning: Begin from the hang position, with your shoulders fully relaxed and scapulas elevated. Initiate the movement by depressing your scapulas. As you move through the position, they will naturally rotate and retract a bit until you reach the top of the position.

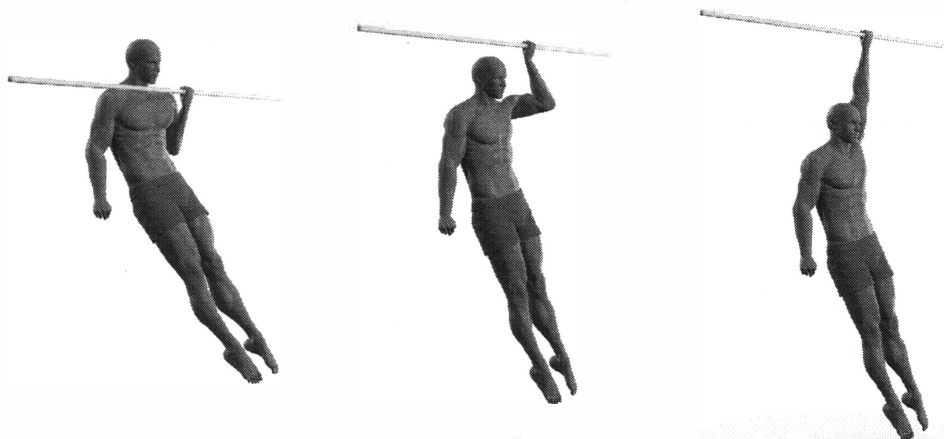
Technique: From the hang position, one of your arms will pull down (like a regular pull-up), while your other arm will remain straight and move into a cross position. Since your straight arm will not be able to provide much assistance, there will be a significant amount of weight on your bent arm. This will make the movement similar to a pseudo one-arm pull-up. You may use a false grip to begin learning this skill, but you will eventually want to be able to perform it without a false grip.

A false grip is attained by shifting your hands up on the side of the ring, so that the crook of your wrist on the pinky side of your hand sits on the rings or bar. Your hand should then be wrapped around the bar or rings and held as tight as possible. From there, the movement may begin. The false grip position will be difficult to attain and/or to maintain if your wrist flexibility is poor, or if you lack grip strength. If this is the case for you, adding supplemental work to correct both of these problems should be included in the warm-up and cool down.

This is the first phase of the one-arm-straight muscle-up and can be used as a progression for building up strength for the cross and one-arm chin-up as well. Emphasis can be placed on either the straight arm (to reinforce the iron cross) or the arm that is bending (for the one-arm chin-up).

Like the previous progressions, this may cause some shoulder issues. Do not place this progression near the end of your routine when you will be most fatigued. It may also be a good idea to perform supplemental rotator cuff muscle work, such as LYTPs, side-lying external rotations, the middle portion of the Cuban press, or band external rotation.

ONE-ARM CHIN-UP / PULL-UP ECCENTRICS – LEVEL 8



Scapular Positioning: Begin at the top of the movement with one hand on the bar and your scapula depressed. Keep your scapulas depressed as you slowly lower to the bottom of the movement. Once you reach the bottom, your arm should be straight. Allow your scapula to slowly elevate at the end of the movement.

Technique: Hold the top of the one-arm position with your hand close to your chest to maximize muscle tension when your chin is over the bar. Slowly lower to a hang position. Control your body as you lower with your shoulder, as well as with the pronation and supination of your forearm.

The best training for the *one-arm chin-up* or *pull-up* is to use their eccentrics or negatives. Here are some prerequisites that are recommended for this movement:

- A chin-up and/or pull-up with an added 50% bodyweight
- At least fifteen strict chin-up/pull-up repetitions to the chest
- Full back lever with hands supinated
- Rings tuck planche

It is critical to be able to do at least a weighted pull-up or chin-up with +50% bodyweight and at least fifteen strict repetitions to the chest, as this ensures both adequate muscular and connective tissue strength. It is also strongly recommended that you have obtained at least a full back lever and a rings tuck planche. These holds also help to build muscular and connective tissue strength from your hands through your forearms, elbows, and biceps area—all the way through to your shoulders and chest.

Having these prerequisites will help prevent overuse injuries—namely tendonitis at your elbows and shoulders. It is also recommended that you can perform a one-armed hang for at least twenty seconds because you will be frequently hanging on one arm as you acquire the one-arm chin-up/one-arm pull-up. If your grip strength is lacking, build it up with farmer's walks, grippers, or other forearm strength exercises.

There are multiple ways to train this skill. This book presents a method acquired based on years of personal experience in training and coaching others. If you want to check out some other sources, you can find great tutorials on beastskills.com and dragondoor.com.

How to achieve a one-arm chin-up/one-arm pull-up:

- Two to three sessions per week of eccentrics
- Zero to one session per week of weighted pull-ups or assisted concentrics

Lets examine a four days per week training schedule over the course of three weeks. With this schedule, there will generally be two days for eccentrics and one day for weighted pull-ups, or one day for assisted concentrics. Programming for a three days per week schedule is similar. It simply spans the exercises over the course of four weeks, accomplishing in a month what is done in three weeks with the four day per week schedule.

Eccentrics are extremely effective with bodyweight exercises, especially pulling movements. Try to perform the movements with as little outside help as possible. Unassisted negatives with one arm should always take precedence over two-arm weighted pull-ups. Assisted concentrics work the whole of the movement to get in some extra practice, but still rely on outside help to be completed. At this point in your journey it is likely that you will have been training for at least a year or two. Even so, intense negatives like these should be limited to two times per week because they are particularly taxing on the central nervous system.

The one-arm chin-up responds best to six to ten second negatives, typically, in two to three sets of two to three repetitions each. Remember, the descent of these movements should be uniform. The top of the movement will be your strongest part; your muscles are in an advantageous position and everyone is freshest at the beginning, so avoid working that first or you will get unbalanced in the skill. The end of the negative is often the most difficult part. Take care not to speed through the eccentric movement before you have reached the fully extended one-arm-hang position.

As a side note, weighted pull-ups and assisted concentrics respond best to three sets of five to eight repetitions. Progress can often be made at about five pounds per workout or every other workout.

You can approach assisted concentrics a few different ways. You can use a pulley system and hang weights that you can hold in your other hand or in a belt. Alternatively, you can hang a rope from the bar and progressively grab lower and lower, forcing your opposite hand to assist less and less. Whatever you choose, know that spotters are not advised for this skill because they tend to help too much and their help is inconsistent.

Here is a list of techniques, starting from the best:

- Eccentrics – They take you through the full range of the motion unassisted, so they tend to work the best. They are particularly good for pulling exercises, of which the one-arm chin-up is one.
- Assisted Pulley Concentrics – Get a pulley and put weight on one end and your hand on the other end. This will assist you measurably, as you can weight it with fifteen pounds, then fourteen pounds, then thirteen pounds, and so forth until you reach one pound. This method is extremely reliable and works well if you want to decrease the amount of eccentrics used.
- Assisted Other Concentrics – You can use another human to assist or finger assist. This works, but not as effectively as the methods listed above.
- Frenchies – Moving up and down within your available range and strength. These are good for solidifying strength within a particular range, but they often do not work the range you are weakest in.
- Isometric Holds – Isometric holds in the range of where you are weak in the movement can be effective at breaking plateaus, but are only minimally effective as a training method.
- Weighted Pull-ups – These are good as a requirement for building strength so that you can safely begin eccentrics, but they are not at all useful in training one-arm exercises because they do not work any specifically one-arm pulling motions.

Finally, you can use progressively fewer fingers on your opposing hand for assistance. Here is a way to work down from the index to pinky fingers, listed from most to least assistance:

- All four fingers
- Index, middle, ring
- Middle, ring, pinky
- Index, middle
- Index, ring
- Index alone
- Middle alone
- Pinky alone
- Ring alone

Occasionally the last progression will be your ring finger then your pinky, but for most people their ring finger is slightly weaker than their pinky. You can also move into these from the archer progression.

One-arm chin-up eccentrics and assisted concentrics will vary from person to person. From the top, you can either face the bar or face it lengthwise. The majority of athletes feel more comfortable looking down the bar (lengthwise) so that their hand is in the “hammer grip” position between pronation and supination. Most people naturally gravitate toward this position. It keeps you from having to actively twist to keep your body facing one way or the other. Likewise, it allows for better squeezing of your arm to your chest, which will help generate more tension for performing the movement.

Whatever your preference, make sure that you practice your chosen technique constantly to achieve the full movement—unless you chose to take the long route to become good at many different types simultaneously. If you are a rock climber, it may be a good idea to practice the one-arm pull-up (with your hand facing away from you) instead, because your hands need to be pronated for performing this movement on climbing holds or ledges. Specificity is king.

Isometric holds at the top, middle, and bottom of the movement may also be of assistance. These are great if you have “sticking points” or “rough patches” that need to be strengthened. Otherwise, they are not particularly useful. For instance, “Frenchies,” in which the negative exercise is performed but the athlete stops and holds in isometric positions along the way, can have a solid place in a program to break “sticking points.”

Grip strength is also an important factor. The stronger you can hold onto the bar, rings, or other surface, the more innervation you can get to your proximal pulling muscles, which will result in a stronger, more concerted pull. If grip strength is limiting you, be sure to add supplemental work to address the issue.

Like the previous progressions, the one-arm chin-up / one-arm pull-up creates significant torque at your shoulder. Like the L-pull-up, wide pull-up, and archer pull-up variations this may cause shoulder discomfort. Do not place this progression near the end of your routine when you will be most likely to be fatigued. It may also be a good idea to perform supplemental rotator cuff muscle work, such as LYTPs, side-lying external rotations, the middle portion of the Cuban press, or band external rotation.

ONE-ARM CHIN-UP – LEVEL 9**ONE-ARM CHIN-UP +15 LBS. – LEVEL 10****ONE-ARM CHIN-UP +25 LBS. – LEVEL 11**

Scapular Positioning: Begin in a one-arm hang position, with your shoulder relaxed. Initiate the movement by depressing and slightly retracting your shoulder blade. As you raise your body to the bar, keep your scapula depressed. You will end with your scapula depressed and close to neutral.

Technique: Get a feel for the rotation by pronating and supinating your forearm. Activate your shoulders by depressing your shoulder blades. Begin the pull and ascend toward the bar. You may notice that you begin to rotate into the bar a bit, with your elbow coming toward your chest. This is acceptable, as it allows your chest contract better. Focus on either pulling your hands down or driving your elbow toward your side—whatever works best for you. Finish with your chin or (preferably) your chest above the bar.

Begin in a hang position with only one arm holding the implement. For the one-arm chin-up, your palm will face you. It is important to get the feeling of controlling your body while only using one arm, before the actual pull is initiated. You can pronate and supinate your forearm to spin around in a circle. Knowing when and how to control this will be extremely helpful during the movement itself. During the movement, your body will naturally want to rotate (depending on individual strengths).

The next step is to tense your shoulder and pull it into the socket to activate it. From there, the initial pull can be thought of in one of two ways: either pulling the point of your elbow down toward your hips, or trying to pull your hand to your shoulder like a biceps curl. These approaches will predominantly activate your lats and biceps, respectively. The best one to use will be whichever feels more natural and stable. This will also let you know the area where you are lacking. While you can always train one-arm chin-ups with the stronger approach, you should also put an effort into correcting the area where you are weaker.

If you started with the pronated hand position (pull-up hand position), you will likely twist ninety degrees as you ascend. If you are using your left hand you will twist ninety degrees to the right. If you are using your right hand you will twist ninety degrees to the left. Go with this movement and really squeeze your arm

against the side of your body to create a lot of tension and improve the overall contraction of your pulling muscles. Tense your core strongly. Sometimes raising your legs or performing this movement in an L-sit or semi-L-sit position makes it easier because of the additional tension from your core. If you started with a supinated hand position (chin-up hand position), keep facing the bar the entire time you are ascending.

If you have a specific weakness, perform supplemental work. Biceps curls can be added to correct the imbalance if you feel too shoulder/lats dominant in this movement. Strength in your biceps and weakness in your lats, on the other hand, requires more straight-arm pulling work like front lever variations, back lever variations, or weighted work like straight-arm lat pull-downs and dumbbell weighted pullovers. Isolation exercises are usually improperly used and overdone, but if there were ever a time to use them, it would be in situations where imbalances need to be corrected.

Once weight is added to a one-arm chin-up or one-arm pull-up, the strength required rivals that of the iron cross. Based on observation, there are similarities in the strength correlation of one-arm chin-ups, one-arm pull-ups, weighted pull-ups, and the iron cross. Understanding this transference to other skills will help you program more competently to achieve your goals as efficiently as possible.

Congratulations on this achievement!



As you improve, you can add weight. Using a weight belt or weight vest is easiest. However, you can just as easily hold a dumbbell in your free hand (and look awesome curling it).

To add challenge, the alternatives to adding weight are: using fewer fingers on your pulling hand, working the other variation (such as one-arm pull-ups if you obtained one-arm chin-ups, or vice versa), or working more range of motion like pulling your chest to the bar as opposed to only getting your chin over the bar. Feel free to work any or all of these variations if they interest you.

Weighted Pull-ups – Page 2, Column 7

There are some interesting correlations among the pulling exercises. The back lever, front lever, one-arm chin-up/pull-up, iron cross, and many other pulling exercises have similar levels of strength that carry over between each of the strength progressions. Here are some estimates on the translation of one to the other:

- Straddle Front Lever = ~50% Bodyweight Pull-up = ~ Full Back Lever
- Front Lever = ~70-80% Bodyweight Pull-up
- One-Arm Chin-up = ~80-90% Bodyweight Pull-up
- 3 One-Arm Chin-ups = +15 lbs. One-Arm Chin-up = 3-4s Iron Cross Hold
- 5 One-Arm Chin-ups = +25 lbs. One-Arm Chin-up = ~10s Iron Cross Hold

Referring back to the progression charts, some of these associations are on the same level on the skill and strength charts. This is what makes the skill and strength progressions charts useful; they allow identification of skills that are at a similar level of ability.

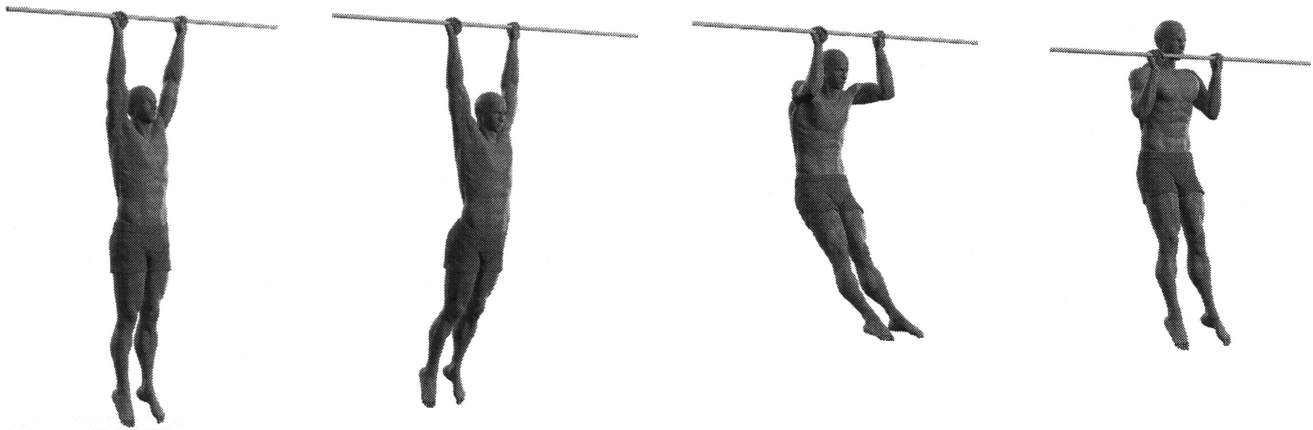
Regarding the translation to the full back lever, it is a bit more variable. The full back lever can be achieved more or less around the straddle FL progression. The straight-arm pulling variations build the shoulder strength to execute the one-arm chin-up, but the front lever does *not* build bent-arm pulling strength due to the high level of biceps stress, whereas the back lever does.

Of course, there is still some level of specificity needed to achieve each of these skills, even when they are ranked at similar levels of strength. Practice what you want to achieve, but in doing so know that supplemental exercises from all of these categories have some carryover to each other.

Explosive Pull-ups – Page 2, Column 8

Explosive pull-up variations can be fun and exciting feats. However, it takes a fair amount of dedication with both explosive and strength work to achieve the higher-level skills. Be diligent when working these progressions and, most importantly, be safe. It is easy to miss and fall so always practice on a soft landing surface. If your strength is lacking, avoid these progressions until you reach level three or four.

KIPPING PULL-UPS – LEVEL 2



Scapular Positioning: During the arch-hollow movement, your scapulas should be relaxed and elevated. During the explosive pull-up portion of the skill, they will be activated to be depressed. At the top of the movement, they will be depressed and slightly retracted. Reverse the process as you descend.

Technique: You will begin in a hang position. Initiate the movement by pushing your shoulders and hips forward. As your abdominals, shoulders, and hips begin to stretch, relax and allow them to contract to pull you backwards, into the hollow position. Repeat this in order to gain more momentum. This time, as you begin to hollow after the arch phase, initiate a pull-up. This should coincide with the closing of your shoulder angle. When your clavicles reach bar-height, do not relax and drop down immediately. (It is preferred that you get your chest to the bar if you have the strength to do so.) Use your muscles to control the movement as you drop back down. From the top of the movement, push away from the bar and allow your arms and shoulders to open in a controlled eccentric motion. This will leave you in the arched starting position.

Kipping pull-ups are a basic movement that utilizes the body's horizontal momentum from below the bar and converts it into vertical momentum to assist with the pulling movement.

Many people consider kipping pull-ups to be a form of cheating; however, they are really their own movement and should be used as such. Compared to regular pull-ups they definitely require less strength, which is why they are ranked lower on the charts, but they can be used fairly effectively as a conditioning movement. They are also important to learn for gymnastics because they translate to many different skills. Even if the added momentum were not needed to compensate for a lack of strength, it is a good idea to at least occasionally practice this movement anyway.

Do not try to learn this movement until you can perform strict dead-hang pull-ups. Additionally, if you have any shoulder issues do not attempt this progression until they are resolved. Very high repetitions of these exercises under fatiguing conditions can lead to injury. If you have any doubts as to whether you are strong enough or sufficiently recovered from an injury, avoid them for now.

If you are having problems getting the movement, or even stringing it together, it may be a good idea to get some coaching by a gymnast or anyone else who knows how to perform the kipping technique. If your shoulders begin to hurt from this movement, take a break. Similarly, if you are jerking around a lot, take a break and just practice the arch to hollow phase.

One of the ways to learn this movement without any abuse on your shoulders is to do it with your feet on the ground to get the feel of the shoulder movements. The key to learning this movement is simply to practice—while it requires some strength, it is mainly the coordination and technique that will need attention.

BAR PULL-UPS – LEVEL 3



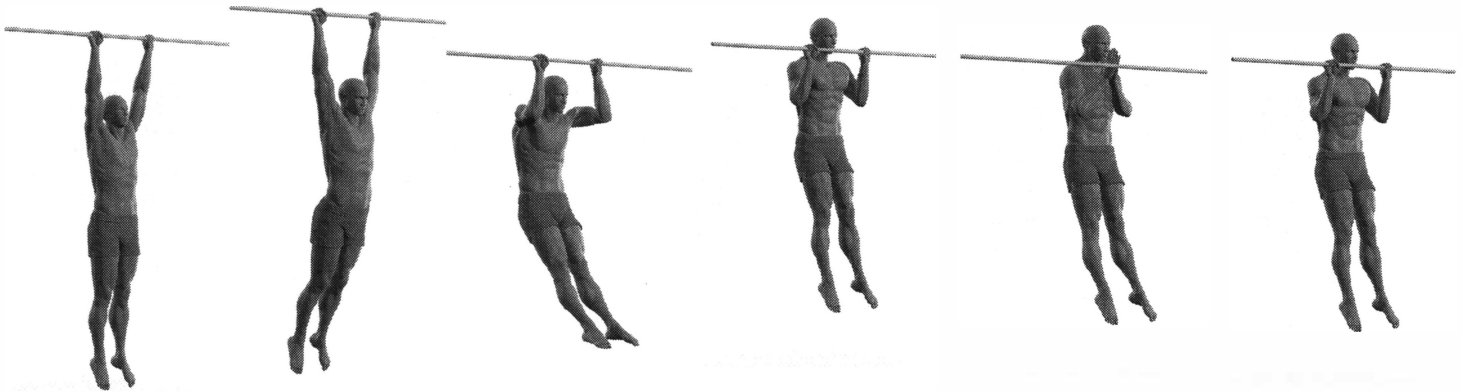
Scapular Positioning: Begin from a hang position, with your shoulders fully relaxed and scapulas elevated. Initiate the movement by depressing your scapulas. As you move through the position they will naturally rotate and retract slightly until you reach the top position.

Technique: Begin from a hang position. Pull your chin over the bar by driving your elbows toward and past your sides. Aim to get your clavicles to the height of the bar without craning your neck. Then, lower back down to a hang position in a controlled manner. Specific elbow technique is elbows in-line with your body, not flared out.

Bar pull-ups are the typical pull-ups you see performed in elementary school gym class. You do not want to have your elbows out wide while performing this movement, as this will limit your vertical pulling ability as your shoulder closes. This will eventually make it difficult to move your chest past the bar in subsequent progressions. Thus, you should keep your elbows in.

If you are having problems at this stage, you can work negatives, assisted pull-ups, or use a Gravitron machine if you have access to one at your local gym. Remember to tense your core and entire shoulder girdle before pulling, as doing so will help transmit the force needed to lift your body.

KIPPING CLAPPING PULL-UPS – LEVEL 4



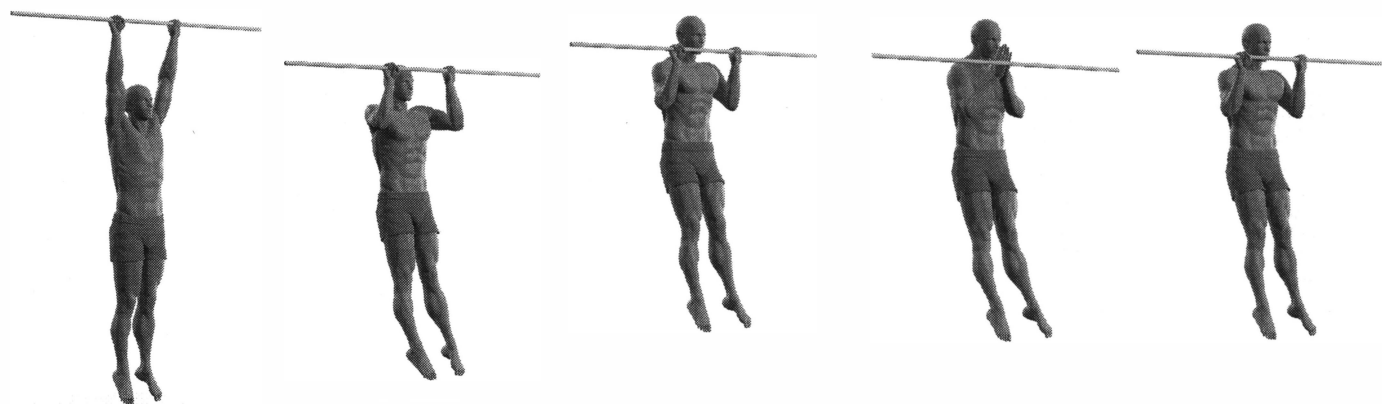
Scapular Positioning: During the arch-hollow movement, your scapulas should be relaxed and elevated. During the explosive pull-up portion, your scapulas should be activated to be depressed. At the top, your scapulas will be depressed and slightly retracted. They will still be depressed after you clap and re-grab the bar. As you descend for the lower part of the movement, elevate them again.

Technique: The kip technique requires an “arch-hollow” technique. During this technique, the oscillation of your body rotates around two points: your hands and your knees. Between your hands and knees are two major fulcrums where the movement will occur. Your hips and shoulders should be thrust forward and backward at the same time, thus moving your body into an arch-hollow rocking motion. During your body’s transition to the hollow phase (when you are ready to begin the movement), pull your hands forward to close your shoulder angle. As your shoulder angle begins to close, pull your hands down strongly to initiate the pull-up with momentum. As your chin ascends over the bar, your hands should be released into the clapping motion as quickly as possible. Likewise, you should re-grab the bar as quickly as possible to avoid plummeting. Lower in a controlled manner if you desire to perform additional repetitions.

The kipping movement allows your body to generate horizontal momentum, which can then be applied vertically in an explosive, full-body contraction that makes upward movement much easier. In many fitness circles kipping is considered cheating; however, kipping can also help develop full-body coordination, develop explosive movement, and can be used as a metabolic conditioning tool. Here it is used as an explosive intermediate to bridge explosive pull-ups to non-kipping clapping pull-ups.

When you first attempt this exercise, be sure to grab some padding or a spotter to make sure you do not slip off and hurt yourself. Never perform this on a surface that may cause your grip to slip.

NON-KIPPING CLAPPING PULL-UPS – LEVEL 5



Scapular Positioning: Begin from a hang position, with your shoulders fully relaxed and scapulas elevated. Initiate the movement by depressing your scapulas. As you move through the position they will naturally rotate and retract slightly until you reach the top position. Next, clap and re-grab the bar. Reverse this process as you descend.

Technique: Begin from a hang position. Pull your chin over the bar by driving your elbows toward and past your sides. Aim to get your clavicles to the height of the bar without craning your neck. Pull explosively, aiming to get the bar approximately three to six inches from your chest as you move behind it. This slight backward motion will help you avoid hitting your head on the bar. After you clap and re-grab the bar, lower back down to a hang position in a controlled manner. Keep your elbows in-line with your body, not flared out.

The technique for this skill requires significantly more brute pulling power than the *kipping clapping pull-up*. Like with the *kipping clapping pull-up*, the clap should be initiated just as your chin clears the bar. In some cases, if the pull is explosive enough, the release can happen once your head or eyes reach the plane of the bar, provided that enough momentum has been generated to allow your chin to be over the bar for the clap. Re-gripping the bar should be quick to avoid falling. Catch the bar and lower yourself in a controlled fashion for additional repetitions.

L-SIT CLAPPING PULL-UPS – LEVEL 6



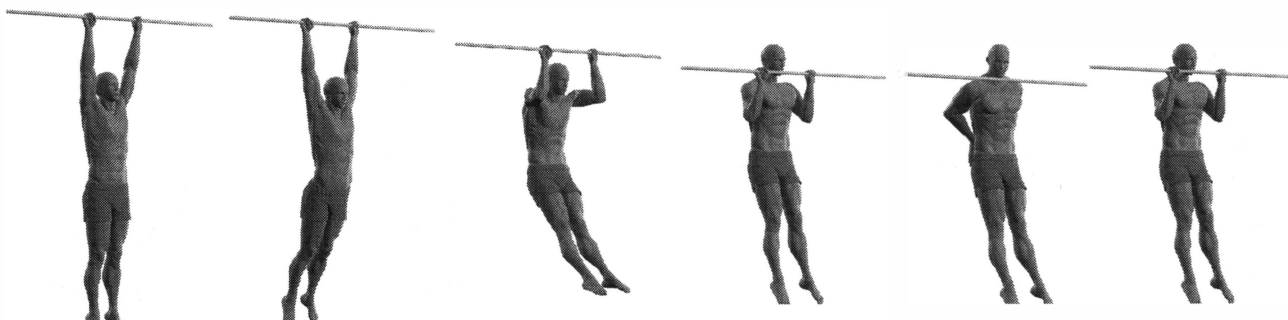
Scapular Positioning: Begin from an L-sit hang position, with your shoulders fully relaxed and scapulas elevated. Initiate the movement by depressing your scapulas. As you move through the position they will naturally rotate and retract slightly until you reach the top position. Clap and re-grab the bar. Reverse this process as you descend.

Technique: Begin from an L-sit hang position. Pull your chin over the bar by driving your elbows toward and past your sides. Aim to get your clavicles to the height of the bar without craning your neck. Pull explosively, aiming to get the bar approximately three to six inches from your chest as you move behind it. This slight backward motion will help you avoid hitting your head on the bar. After you clap and re-grab the bar, lower back down to a hang position in a controlled manner. Keep your elbows in-line with your body, not flared out.

L-sit clapping pull-ups are the first generation of explosive pull-ups that add the L-sit to decrease leverage at the shoulder, thus increasing the difficulty level. Since the L-sit forces your center of mass forward, the angle at your shoulder is increased, so that it will require much more force to generate the same vertical momentum used to propel your body upward.

In this specific technique there is no need to focus on pulling a few inches in front of your chest. Your hands will already be in front of your chest by a couple of inches, which decreases the leverage. The main focus is keeping your toes elevated in the L-sit position by keeping your abdominals contracted, and pulling your hands down and your elbows to your sides as quickly as possible. It is a much different movement than the explosive pull-ups previously described; therefore, it will require a bit more practice. This is the first movement in this progression without a kip, besides the standard pull-up.

KIPPING, BEHIND-THE-BACK CLAPPING PULL-UPS – LEVEL 7



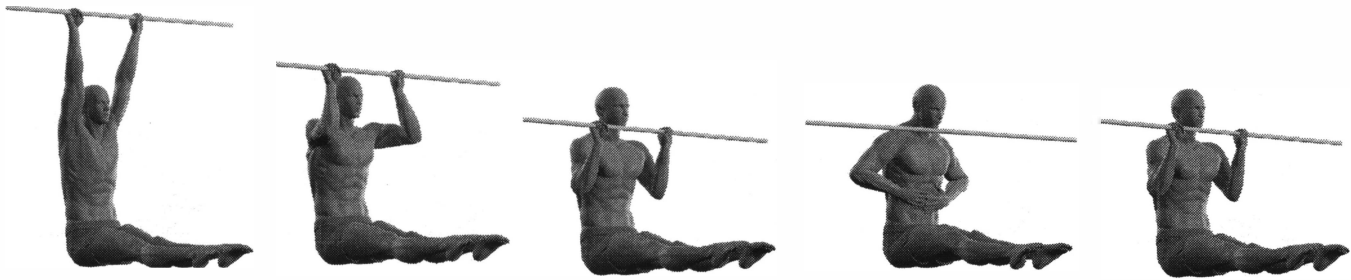
Scapular Positioning: During the arch-hollow movement, your scapulas should be relaxed and elevated. During the explosive pull-up portion, your scapulas should be activated to be depressed. At the top, your scapulas will be depressed and slightly retracted. They will still be depressed after you clap and re-grab the bar. As you descend for the lower part of the movement, elevate them again.

Technique: The technique for initiating the kip is the same. Create the “arch-hollow” rocking motion and build it as much as you comfortably can for the transition into the pull-up. When the hollow phase begins, pull aggressively in a downward direction. Let go four to six inches before the apex of the movement is reached (the point at the top of the movement where gravity will slow you down). This can be gauged from the speed of ascent and takes a bit of practice to master. You will have a bit of extra time to perform the clap, as your body will continue to rise until it hits the apex and begins descending. This works better than releasing at the top of the movement and descending immediately. Once you clap and re-grab the bar, lower in a controlled manner if you desire to perform additional repetitions.

Kipping, behind-the-back clapping pull-ups allow you to harness kipping explosively. By exploiting a huge kip, this movement is potentially easier to perform than the previous progression. However, because it is harder for those with very little kipping experience, it has been given a higher difficulty level.

After the release, move your hands behind your back to clap and quickly get them back around to the front of your body. This will require a significant amount of coordination. Not only do your hands have to be removed from the bar to clap, they must also be returned to the bar as you begin to fall. When you begin training this skill, make sure there are soft mats beneath you!

L-SIT, SLAP-THE-ABDOMINALS PULL-UPS – LEVEL 8



Scapular Positioning: Begin from an L-sit hang position, with your shoulders fully relaxed and scapulas elevated. Initiate the movement by depressing your scapulas. As you move through the position they will naturally rotate and retract slightly until you reach the top position. Next, slap your abdominals and re-grab the bar. Reverse this process as you descend. The scapulas should be fully depressed at the top and while slapping.

Technique: Begin from an L-sit hang position. Pull your chin over the bar by driving your elbows toward and past your sides. Aim to get your clavicles to the height of the bar without craning your neck. Pull explosively, aiming to get the bar approximately three to six inches from your chest as you move behind it. This slight backward motion will help you avoid hitting your head on the bar. After you slap your abdominals and re-grab the bar, lower back down to an L-sit hang position in a controlled manner. Your elbows should remain in line with your body, not flared out.

With *L-sit, slap-the-abdominals pull-ups* you will begin to increase the distance of the target of your hands, as it requires a more explosive pulling phase to create the necessary additional time in the air for your hands to reach their target and return to the bar. The ability to pull significantly above chin height will likely be required before you can execute this skill. This is because the higher you pull, the closer your hands will already be to the target area that is to be slapped/clapped. Normally, this would be considered cheating; however, since it requires a stronger and more significantly higher pull (which in turn ensures explosiveness), it is in line with your ultimate goal.

You will probably find it easier to pull up to approximately the nipple area of your chest. With your hands already close to your abdominals, apply a quick slap and re-grip the bar as soon as possible. This movement requires an extremely strong pulling ability. I would estimate that a beginner who can complete this technique can likely also perform weighted pull-ups with an additional 60-75% of bodyweight.

L-SIT, SLAP-THE-THIGHS PULL-UPS – LEVEL 9

Scapular Positioning: Begin from an L-sit hang position, with your shoulders fully relaxed and scapulas elevated. Initiate the movement by depressing your scapulas. As you move through the position they will naturally rotate and retract slightly until you reach the top position. Next, slap your thighs and re-grab the bar. Reverse this process as you descend. The scapulas should be fully depressed at the top and while slapping.

Technique: Begin from an L-sit hang position. Pull your chin over the bar by driving your elbows toward and past your sides. Aim to get your clavicles to the height of the bar without craning your neck. Pull explosively, aiming to get the bar approximately three to six inches from your chest as you move behind it. This slight backward motion will help you avoid hitting your head on the bar. After you slap your thighs and re-grab the bar, lower back down to an L-sit hang position in a controlled manner. Specific elbow technique is elbows in-line with your body, not flared out.

L-sit, slap-the-thigh pull-ups take the previous skill one step beyond the abdominals and require an extra four to six inches of hand movement while airborne. At this point, your strength level can be compared to performing a pull-up with an additional 75-90% of your bodyweight. It is also around this point that a one-arm chin-up or pull-up can also be acquired.

There are two ways to execute this technique. Choose the one that you prefer. First, you can pull more explosively and let go at approximately chest/nipple height, much like the previous slap-abs exercise, and afterward simply move your hands very quickly. The alternative is to aim to do a more explosive pull-up and grip the bar until your middle abdominal area reaches the bar before letting go.

STRAIGHT-BODY, SLAP-THE-THIGHS PULL-UPS – LEVEL 10



Scapular Positioning: Begin from a hang position, with your shoulders fully relaxed and scapulas elevated. Initiate the movement by depressing your scapulas. As you move through the position they will naturally rotate and retract slightly until you reach the top position. Next, slap your thighs while keeping your arms straight and re-grab the bar. Reverse this process as you descend. The scapulas should be fully depressed at the top and while slapping.

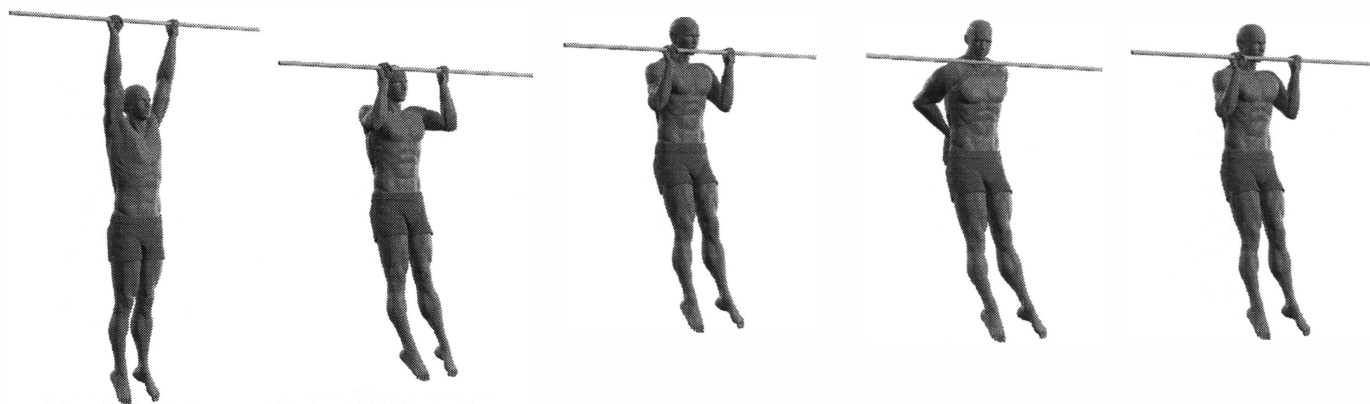
Technique: Begin from a hang position. Pull your chin over the bar by driving your elbows toward and past your sides. Aim to get your clavicles to the height of the bar without craning your neck. Pull explosively, aiming to get the bar approximately three to six inches from your chest as you move behind it. This slight backward motion will help you avoid hitting your head on the bar. Next, slap your thighs while keeping your arms straight and re-grab the bar, then lower back down to an L-sit hang position in a controlled manner. Keep your elbows in line with your body, not flared out.

There are two ways you can perform *straight-body, slap-the-thigh pull-ups*. The advisable way is to explosively pull up to at least abdominal height. The alternative, although it is a valid method is to “game the system.” You could technically perform a full-muscle up, hop up off the bar, slap, and re-grip. This is actually fairly easy, especially if you pause after the muscle-up and before the hop.

But you’re an athlete. The objective of this movement is to develop superior pulling strength and not to “game the system” to obtain a really cool skill. Pausing after a muscle-up before hopping to perform a clap or slap does not develop explosive pulling strength.

If you can execute this movement correctly, your pulling strength is probably around what is needed to complete a pull-up with an additional amount of weight equal to 95-105% of your bodyweight. And it’s honest strength, not a visual trick.

NON-KIPPING, BEHIND-THE-BACK CLAPPING PULL-UPS – LEVEL 11



Scapular Positioning: Begin from a hang position, with your shoulders fully relaxed and scapulas elevated. Initiate the movement by depressing your scapulas. As you move through the position they will naturally rotate and retract slightly until you reach the top position. Clap behind your back and re-grab the bar. Reverse this process as you descend. The scapulas should be fully depressed at the top and while clapping.

Technique: Begin from a hang position. Pull your chin over the bar by driving your elbows toward and past your sides. Aim to get your clavicles to the height of the bar without craning your neck. Pull explosively, aiming to get the bar approximately three to six inches from your chest as you move behind it. This slight backward motion will help you avoid hitting your head on the bar. Next, quickly clap behind your back and re-grab the bar, then lower back down to an L-sit hang position in a controlled manner. Your elbows should stay in line with your body, not flared out.

Non-kipping, behind-the-back clapping pull-ups are one of the ultimate expressions of explosive pulling strength. As of this writing, no one has succeeded in performing this skill. Cisco, who is known for his one-arm rope climb and 7+ OAC/OAP in a row has attempted it on YouTube. Achieving this skill would surely earn you some notoriety.

Based on previous progressions and some reasonable assumption, the key here will be an extremely aggressive, explosive pull-up to approximately mid-abdominal height. Very quick hands will be a necessity in order to clap and return to the bar before you crash into the ground. As such, practicing the arm movement for the clap would also be suggested, because fast hand movement is absolutely a must before you even consider attempting this skill.

If you are at the point of attempting this skill, good luck. You already have impressive explosive pulling ability! Only the best wishes in your pursuit of this incredible feat.

Iron Cross – Page 2, Column 9

The *iron cross* could really have its own chapter. The technique and demands of this position, especially on your connective tissues, is high and can easily lead to overuse injuries if you do not approach it properly.

In the skill progressions chart, the recommended prerequisites that will help develop adequate connective tissue and joint preparation for iron cross training are shaded. These are as follows:

1. Rings Strap Handstand Pushups
2. L-Sit / Straddle-L Straight-Arm Press Handstands
3. Full Back Lever (with Supinated Hands)
4. Half Layout / One-Leg-Extended Front Lever
5. Rings Advanced Tuck Planche
6. Rings Dips (Deep and Rings-Turned-Out to 75 Degrees Past Parallel)

Having this base amount of strength is crucial because the iron cross is executed with your body in an extremely disadvantaged position, more so than any of the moves above. You do not want any potential injuries to develop, and having enough base strength to safely begin iron cross progressions is key.

All of the listed skills have a couple of things in common. Rings handstands ensure proper development of pressing strength, especially of your anterior shoulder (which takes a lot of force during iron cross training). All of the straight-arm work from straight-arm press handstands, full back lever, front lever, and the planche will ensure that the connective tissues in your shoulders and forearms are able to safely support your bodyweight under conditions of disadvantaged leverage.

The rings-turned-out dips in particular have a stress component on your elbows and chest that mimic much of the stress that is experienced in the iron cross position. For rings-turned-out dips, you must first be competent in holding the rings for at least thirty seconds while they are turned out to the ninety-degree position (palms fully forward). This causes a lot of strain on your inner elbow, biceps, and chest. This stress is a driver for the adaptation needed to protect your body from the harshness of iron cross training.

IRON CROSS PROGRESSIONS – LEVEL 9

Methods of Training

Four common methods of training toward the iron cross are listed below. They are ordered from most to least effective. It is preferable to simulate the cross position as best as possible, including keeping yourself on the rings.

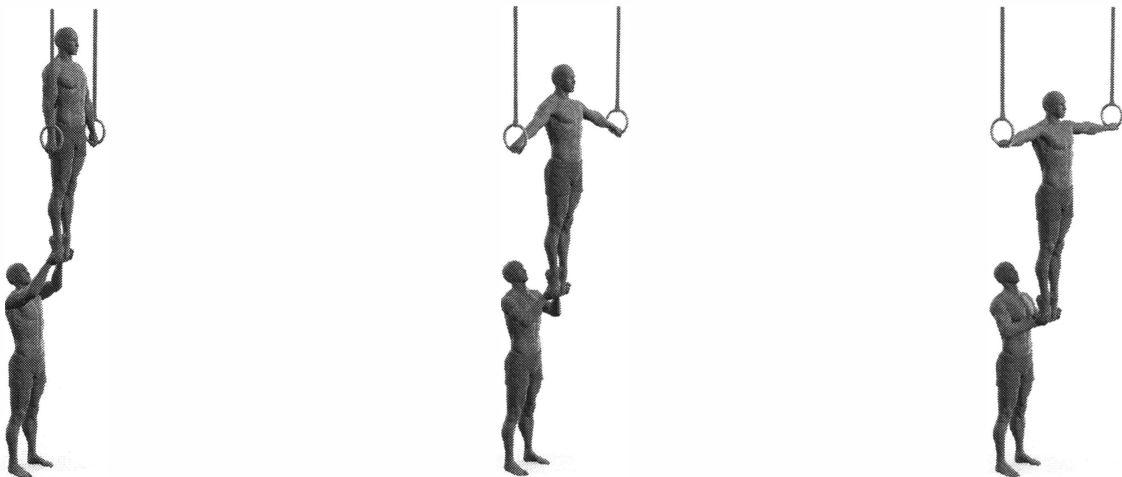
1. Partner-assisted crosses are the best. They require your muscles to be at or near maximum effort the whole time, which is extremely good for developing strength and muscle mass (provided that you are eating enough). Additionally, a training partner makes workouts more effective through encouragement and friendly competition.
2. The second best option would be Theraband cross pullouts with weighted progressions or a dream machine device with pulleys connected to weights (or your bodyweight). It simulates the cross position very well and is scalable with weights to mark continual strength progress. For the weighted progressions, dumbbells, weighted vests, or other implements can be used provided there is a system to consistently add or subtract weight from your body.
3. Block cross pullouts tend to place a bit more stress on your lats as opposed to your pecs. For this single reason they are rated third of these methods. On the other hand, block cross pullouts can be effective because your progress can be measured either by how much of your legs are on the block or by the height of the block itself.

Last, but not least is the Theraband-assisted cross (with therabands of different colors). It is rated last because the force is less measurable, making progress less consistent. If using a block feels unnatural you can switch to these instead, but do your absolute best to keep everything consistent to ensure steady progression. If using this method, pick something that makes you struggle but allows you to eventually push through.

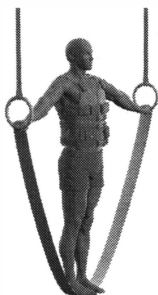
Pressing the rings into your forearms to decrease leverage is a valid method; however, performing iron cross exercises this way does not sufficiently prepare your connective tissues. It is often the case that strength training for the iron cross may be limited by the ability of your connective tissues to adapt to the stress. The connective tissues that are most affected are the ones at your elbow (medial epicondyle) and shoulder (rotator cuff and surrounding muscular stabilizers).

Another alternative for exercises is using a dream machine.

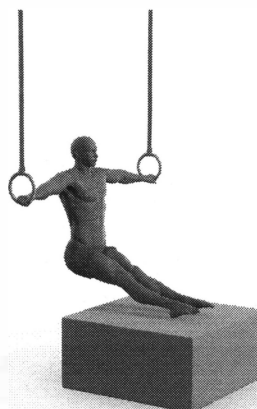
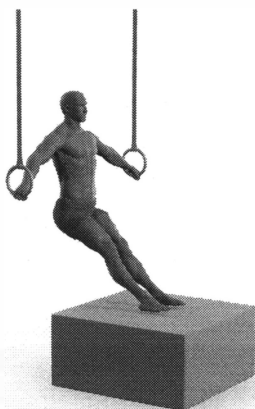
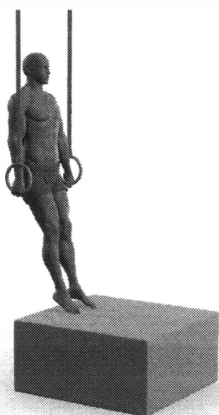
Assisted Crosses



Theraband Cross Pullouts with a Weighted Vest



Block Cross Pullouts



Theraband Cross Pullouts



Dream Machine



The Technique

- Begin in a support hold position with your elbows locked and shoulder girdle depressed.
- Turn the rings out (*RTO—rings-turned-out*) by rotating your palms so they face completely forward.
- When lowering, rotate your shoulder forward while keeping your elbows oriented in a forward direction. They may begin to spin and face the ground. This is fine.
- As you get lower and enter the cross position, make sure you are constantly depressing your shoulder girdle and locking all of the muscles around your shoulder tightly in order to prevent scapular destabilization.

You must eliminate the two biggest flaws that occur during this process, lest bad habits develop:

- Your elbows must be locked straight at all times. It is a common bad habit to bend your arms, because doing so lessens torque at your shoulder. However, also puts more tension on your latissimus dorsi, which is stronger than your pectoralis muscle groups. Avoid this at all costs.
- As your latissimus and pectoralis muscle groups become fatigued it is common to see your shoulder girdle elevate. This is a sign that your musculature can no longer safely support your shoulders and greatly increases your chances of shoulder injury. If you feel your shoulders starting to get closer to your ears, terminate the set immediately because it is very easy to aggravate the soft tissues there which may lead to rotator cuff tendonitis, strains, or shoulder impingement.

If rolling your shoulders forward aggravates them, it is possible to keep your shoulder in a neutral position with depressed scapulas, though this is a bit tough on your elbows. For those who have had previous shoulder issues, this technique may be worth considering. If you would like to attempt this technique, make sure your elbows are safe before going all-out on exercises, as you will lose the ability of your shoulders to naturally lock themselves when in the cross position.

When training the actual movement, make sure to warm up thoroughly. Any of the prerequisites are solid for warming up your elbows for the iron cross. Specific scapular drills like those found in the prehabilitation section of this book (Chapter 22) are also effective. Basically, you want to warm up every part of your shoulder before attempting to train this movement because it can be rough on the connective tissues in your shoulder. If you have not added rotator cuff training with internal and external rotations to your routine, do so now.

The current official Gymnastics Code requires you to not have a false grip when performing the cross because it makes it easier to obtain the position. However, while you are learning, it is acceptable to slide into a false grip while turning the rings out and lowering into the position.

Please note: the cross can cause damage to your shoulder and elbows if your muscles and connective tissues are not adequately prepared. *If you have not obtained all of the prerequisites listed on the charts, do not attempt any of the progressions in this section.*

For an extensive article on the iron cross originally published on Catalyst Athletics, see this link: steven-low.org/ironcross

HOLD IRON CROSS – LEVEL 10



Scapular Positioning: Depending on the technique you are using, your scapulas will either be depressed and slightly protracted or depressed and neutral as you lower into the iron cross position.

Technique: Your arms will be held straight out in line with your body at a ninety-degree angle. Lock them in this position and keep your shoulders down. You will be pulling the rings downward toward your hips to hold this position.

Now that you are very close to the iron cross or can momentarily pause in the position, it is time to integrate more assisted holds into your program in order to neurologically prime your body to hit the exact hold you want. You will begin your training with mostly eccentric/concentric movements. Upon these you can build a base of strength that encompasses all ranges of motion.

If you are training this position alone it may be very difficult to move your body from any type of support or movement into the hold. Strengthening the full movement helps extensively with most other corollary pulling movements like back lever, front lever, and one-arm chin-ups.

More information on recommended programming can be found in the online article referenced in the previous section. The sample programming section of this book also discusses some specific programming. Traditional light/heavy days work well in a comprehensive program. A system with daily-undulated periodization also works well.

This is a B-level skill in the Gymnastics Code of Points.

IRON CROSS TO BACK LEVER – LEVEL 11

Scapular Positioning: Depending on the technique you are using, your scapulas will either be depressed and slightly protracted or depressed and neutral as you lower into the iron cross position. As you move into the back lever position, your scapulas will naturally retract but end neutral.

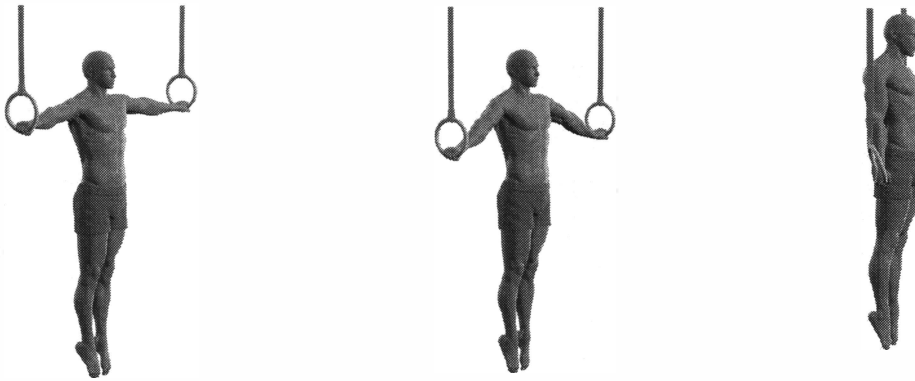
Technique: For the iron cross, your arms will be held straight out in line with your body at a ninety-degree angle. Lock them in this position and keep your shoulders down. You will be pulling the rings downward toward your hips to hold the iron cross position. To initiate the movement into the back lever position, begin to lean forward and pull the rings back slightly. Continue to exert downward force on the rings as you do this. As you lean forward, you will eventually reach a tipping point where gravity takes over. Control the transition as much as you can.

The key with this skill is to get the feel of maintaining the downward force on the rings from the cross as you transition into a back lever. You must continually contract your lats, especially as you lean your upper body forward. Try to get a feel for it in the dream machine or with a spotter before attempting it yourself.

One thing that may cause problems is the “fall.” If you are not strong enough to lower slowly and under control, your body will jerk when you get into the back lever position. This can be tough on your shoulders and elbows. If this is the case it may be a good idea to back off and focus on strength work. Or, you can utilize the dream machine or spotter.

This is a B-level skill in the Gymnastics Code of Points.

IRON CROSS PULLOUTS – LEVEL 13



Scapular Positioning: Depending on the technique you are using, your scapulas will either be depressed and slightly protracted or depressed and neutral as you lower into the iron cross position. During your ascent, your scapulas will remain slightly protracted and depressed or neutral and stay that way in support.

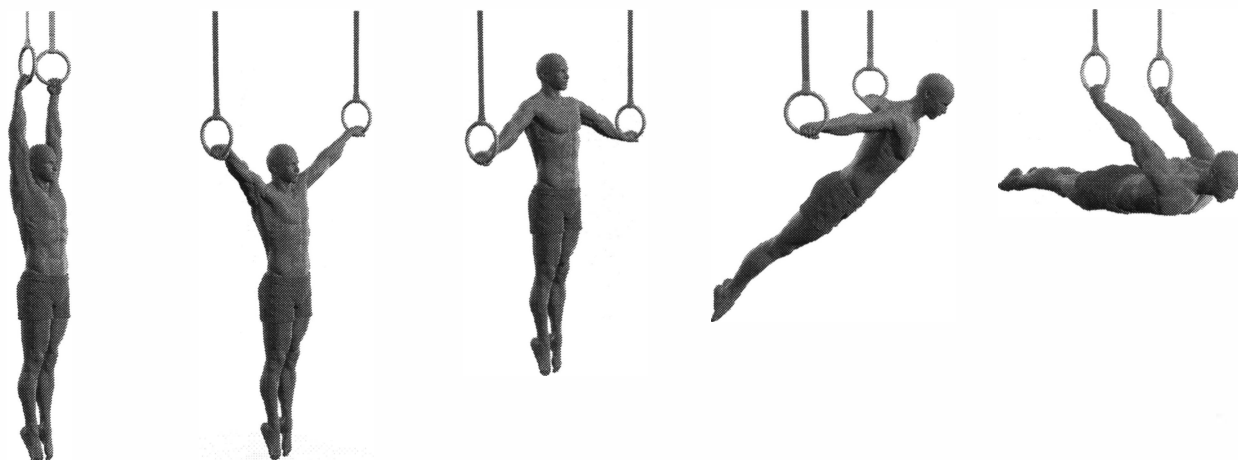
Technique: Your arms will be held straight out in line with your body at a ninety-degree angle. Lock them in this position and keep your shoulders down. You will be pulling the rings downward toward your hips to hold this position. Next, push down extremely hard, keeping your arms straight as you bring them in to your sides while your hands remain in the rings-turned-out position.

A significant amount of strength is required to pull oneself out of the iron cross from a static position. It may be useful to continue with regular assisted cross pullouts and slowly decrease the resistance until you can perform them without assistance.

There are two different ways to think about moving your hands. You can pull your arms down to the side, or you can push your hands downward. You should use whichever concept helps you focus best. Do note that since your center of mass moves toward your hands and this movement focuses on working your pecs and lats (both pulling muscles), this is classified as a pulling exercise.

The pullouts require a significantly greater amount of strength than the isometric portion of the movement. This is where adrenaline and the supramaximal 120% 1 RM come into play.

This is a C-level skill in the Gymnastics Code of Points.

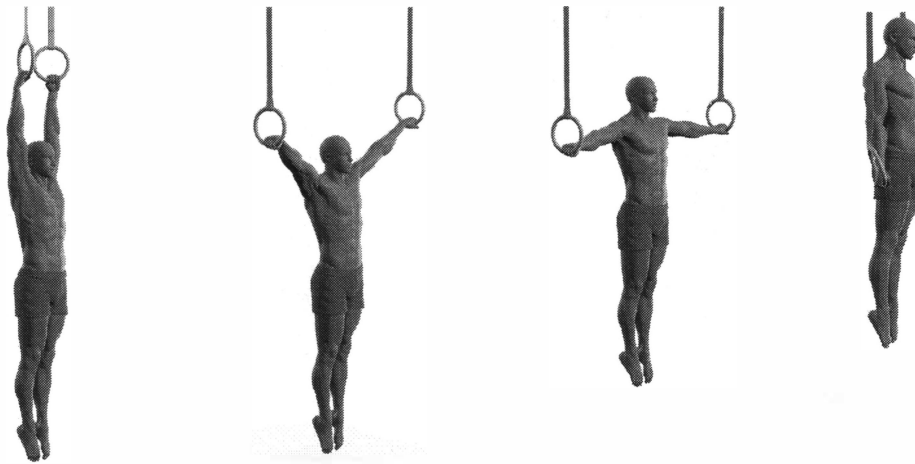
HANG PULL TO BACK LEVER – LEVEL 14

Scapular Positioning: Begin with your scapulas elevated and relaxed. Initiate the movement by activating your shoulders and depressing the scapulas. Your scapulas will protract slightly through the pull to the cross. They will retract as you pass the cross position and begin to lean forward. When you end in the back lever position your scapulas will be neutral.

Technique: Begin in a hang position with straight arms and a false grip. From there, perform a straight-arm pull by forcing your hands downward. Keep your hands slightly in front of your body for more leverage. As soon as you are near the cross position, lean forward while maintaining straight-arm positioning. As you are falling forward into the back lever position, engage your lats further to slow down your descent; otherwise you will strain your shoulders and elbows.

This skill is difficult because it begins from a dead hang. If you are struggling to pull out of the bottom of the skill, one of the ways to build momentum involves pulling the rings in before forcing them outward. This provides your arms a bit of momentum before the pull initiation. You could also raise your legs into a semi-L-sit position to generate a bit of upward force to help initiate the strength movement. Ultimately, you will want to eliminate the assistance of momentum from this skill.

This is a C-level skill in the Gymnastics Code of Points.

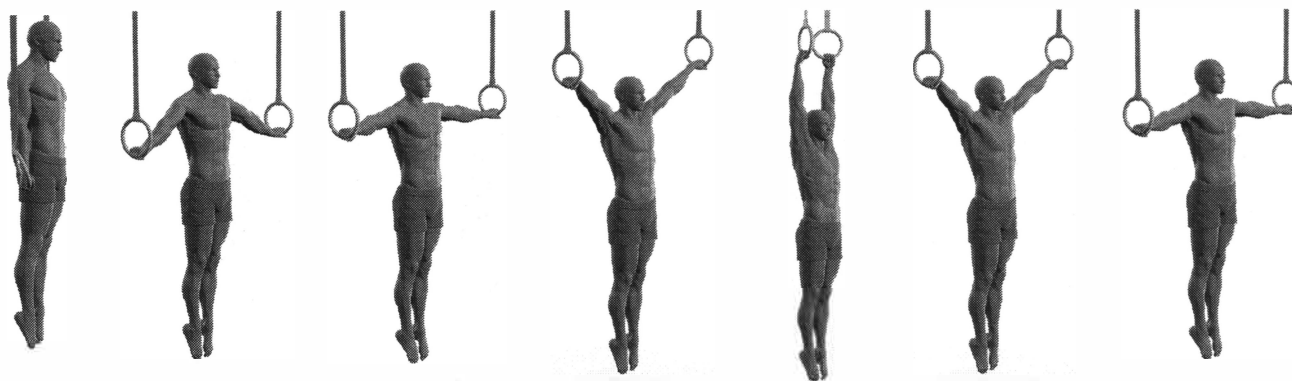
BUTTERFLY MOUNT – LEVEL 15

Scapular Positioning: Begin with your scapulas elevated and relaxed. Initiate the movement by activating your shoulders and depressing the scapulas. Your scapulas will protract slightly through the pull to the cross. As you pass the cross position, they will stay either depressed and neutral or slightly protracted all the way to the support position.

Technique: Begin in a hang position with straight arms and a false grip. From there, perform a straight-arm pull by forcing your hands downward. You will want your hands to be slightly in front of your body for more leverage. As you approach the cross position, keep forcing the rings downward to maintain any momentum you may have. If you slow down or pause, you will likely get stuck and not have enough strength to complete the skill.

This skill is essentially a straight-arm muscle-up-to-support hold. It is an amazing feat of pulling strength. Like the previous skill, the difficult part is beginning from a dead hang. If you are struggling to pull out of the bottom of the skill, one of the ways to build momentum is to pull the rings in before forcing them outward. This provides your arms a bit of momentum before the pull initiation. You can also raise your legs into a semi-L-sit position to generate a bit of upward force to help initiate the strength movement. Ultimately, you will want to eliminate the assistance of momentum from this skill.

This is a C-level skill in the Gymnastics Code of Points.

SUPPORT HOLD TO HANG TO IRON CROSS – LEVEL 16

Scapular Positioning: Begin with your scapulas depressed. Initiate the movement by lowering through the cross position to a hang position. Once you reach this position, reverse your downward motion by relaxing your scapulas—elevating and depressing them again. As you move up to the cross position, your scapulas will remain either depressed and neutral or slightly protracted.

Technique: Beginning from the support position, slowly lower through the cross position to a hang position. Use a false grip, since you will be pulling straight out of the position once you reach the bottom. When you reach the hang position, immediately pull your arms out and down. This will raise your body up to the support position.

This is an extension of the previous skill. It bridges the gap between the *butterfly mount* and the *butterfly cross*, which is a *hang pull to cross*. This skill requires a significant amount of energy to control the lowering movement from a support hold, through the cross, and down to the hang position. This subsequently makes the pull out of the bottom of the movement difficult, in spite of the fact that you may get momentum from your hands.

Like the previous skills, you can use this momentum (or the momentum from moving your body into the semi-L-sit position) to assist you in moving out of the bottom of this strength movement. Remember, you will ultimately want to eliminate the assistance of momentum from this skill.

This is a C-level skill in the Gymnastics Code of Points. The butterfly cross, which is not addressed in this book, is approximately a Level 17 skill and has a D-rating in the Gymnastics Code of Points. That skill begins from a hang position and pulls to a cross.